

More Wi-Fi

The next generation Wi-Fi technology, 802.11n, has finally been approved as the standard, even though it was conceived seven years ago

Power of the sun

Students from Tuft University and the Boston Architectural College have created a house that runs completely on Solar Energy



A corny design from tshirts.in



Some inkfruit designs



or fantastically tongue-in-cheek witty as you want.

There are many websites that have entered the fray to offer custom T-shirts among other customised stuff like mugs, mouse pads and stickers. A class of web sites in this segment are primarily photo printing web sites such as zoomin.com that also let you print photos on T-shirts. Then there are dedicated personalisation web sites like early entrant myntra.com and several others including pringoo.com and dilsebol.com. The last category of T-shirt web sites do allow you to submit your own designs but for shopping on the fly you need to bank upon the hundreds of crazy designs already created by their designer communities. Let's have a look at some of the web sites and what they have to offer.

myntra.com is by far India's largest on-demand consumer products personalisation brand. The web site is easy to navigate and their after sales service is excellent. For customising products the web site has a nice applet which lets you add text and upload your own images while showing an instant preview. The user-generated designs and one-liners are not as snappy as some of the other players but there is certainly quantity. You have loads and loads of categories and thousands of designs to choose from. Look for the Digital world and Nerd categories under Life. The pricing too is reasonable. Head over to myntra.com for a clean shopping / gifting experience and look out for their collaborative offers. pringoo.com is yet another custom design franchise offering you pretty much everything including custom T-shirts, stickers and even chocolate wrappers powered by Cadbury's. The designing applet works really well but doesn't offer as many fonts as Myntra. The community generated designs are especially witty. The "computer age" and "gaming" categories have nice designs. We found one that says

"PC Problem? Date a geek" and others that are too raunchy to even mention! Dilsebol.com really has nothing to offer that's worth writing home about. The design tool is very buggy, while browsing through other designs is painful. The only thing worth mentioning was the option to modify pre-existing designs. Now we come down to the last category of web sites that allow you to submit designs into the general pool of designs, but if the design is ever to see the front of a T-shirt it needs to be really good and hence approved. The benefit of this is that you get access to a set of really high quality designs and a vibrant active designer community. In this space we have tshirts.in, inkfruit.com and bluebustees.com. tshirts.in may not look all hot a site but has some really nice designs.

The slogans are insanely funny and the t-shirts quite affordable. inkfruit.com has

by far the most artistic designs and actual photographs of T-shirts being worn. We quite liked some of the Pac man and Tetris prints. Being the sentimental geeks that we are the first thought they evoked was "now that's cool". Then there are noteworthy vector art creations. The web sites offers its designer community several competitions and prizes. So if you feel you have it in you, be a prosumer and submit your own designs.

Next up bluebustees.com has two very disparate and interesting categories for browsing, viz. Parents Approved and Parents NOT Approved. Without going into details the category names should give you a fair idea of what you can expect in each. So go ahead create your own or choose designs that speak to you and express yourself. We're pretty sure you'll turn a few heads. **d**

T-SHIRT PRINTING TECHNOLOGY

We were quite curious to know more about the actual technology that enables printing on T-Shirts. What are the different processes? Which one is more suited for a particular cloth or colour scheme etc. So, we met Mr. Mukesh Bansal, CEO of Myntra.com for some insights into this field. There are currently four types of printing technologies being used. Screen Printing is a more traditional type of technology. It is used for printing T-shirts in bulk where you have only a fixed number of colours. If there are four colours a screen will be printed for each of the colours. Only the part that is treated gets transferred with a run of each screen. That way there is a limitation of six to eight colours. So, in this type of printing you need bulk for the economies of scale to apply, otherwise one T-shirt will cost you Rs. 5000 which is not very practical. For printing single T-shirts one of the technologies available is sublimation. This can work only work

for poly-cotton T-shirts. The design is first printed on paper with a special ink, which doesn't get absorbed on the paper. Then the paper is heat-pressed on the cloth so the colour gets absorbed on the cloth. The finish comes out good but this is limited to white polycottons. At the most very light colours. Then there is something called DTG (Direct to Garment) Printing. This is basically a modified inkjet and can work on any kind of surface. It supports 32 bit colour printing. The machine pretty much also looks like an inkjet printer. Lastly there is Print and Cut which is used for intricate designs. In this form the design is first printed on a special media and the outline is cut before being heat pressed onto the fabric. Vendors need to make a choice between these technologies depending on the formulation of design; whether it consists of a photograph, slogan, or vector graphics etc. and the type of fabric and colour that was chosen.